The Maiden without Hands

By Anne Sexton

Is it possible

he marries a cripple

out of admiration?

A desire to own the maiming

so that not one of us butchers

will come to him with crowbars

or slim precise tweezers?

Lady, bring me your wooden leg

so I may stand on my own

two pink pit feet.

If someone burns out your eye

I will take your socket

and use it for an ashtray.

If they have cut out your uterus

I will give you a laurel wreath

to put in its place.

If you have cut off your ear

4NG Fanatics

I will give you a crow

who will hear just as well.

My apple has no worm in it!

My apple is whole!

INTRODUCTION

We all need fairy tales. We read them or watched them as children and they serve as little idealistic beacons of hope once we reach adulthood. Then there are those who worry that all this exposure to happily ever after can warp our brains and leave us unprepared for the harsh reality that life has to offer. But regardless of the happily every eafter endings, there is no denying that many of the events that occur in our fairy tales are dark, scary, and intimidating events. Perhaps none as dark as the one that I have prepared for you today - A strange retelling of the Grimms' fairy tale in which a wizard tricks a miller into giving him his daughter and then forces the miller to cut off her hands. The girl runs away, has good fortune, but is once again plagued by the malicious wizard. This adaptation is called The Maiden without Hands and is prepared in poetry format by Anne Sexton.

Once

there was a cruel father

who cut off his daughter's hands

to escape from the wizard.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

The maiden held up her stumps
as helpless as dog's paws
and that made the wizard
want her. He wanted to lap
her up like strawberry preserve.
She cried on her stumps
as sweet as lotus water,
as strong as petroleum,
as sure-fire as castor oil.
Her tears lay around her like a moat.
Her tears so purified her
that the wizard could not approach.

She left her father's house
to wander in forbidden woods,
the good, kind king's woods.
She stretched her neck like an elastic,
up, up, to take a bite of a pear.
handing from the king's tree.
Picture her there for a moment,
a perfect still life.

4NG Fanatics

After all,
she could not feed herself
or pull her pants down
or brush her teeth.

She was, I'd say,
without resources.
The king spied upon her at
that moment of stretching up, up
and he thought,
Eeny, Meeny, Miny, Mo –
There but for the grace of --
I will take her for my wife.

And thus they were married
and lived together on a sugar cub.
The king had silver hands made for her.
they were polished daily and kept in place,
little tin mittens.
The court bowed at the sight of them from a distance.
The leisurely passerby stopped and crossed himself.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

What a fellow he is, they said of the king,
and kept their lips pursed as for a kiss.
But that was not the last word
for the king was called to war.
Naturally the queen was pregnant
so the king left her in care of his mother.
Buy her a perambulator, he said,
and send me a message when my son is born.
Let me hear no catcalls
or see a burned mattress.
He wad superstitious.
You can see his point of view.

When the son wads born
the mother sent a message
but the wizard intercepted it,
saying, instead, a changeling was born.
The king didn't mind.
He was used to this sort of thing by now.
He said: Take care,
but the wizard intercepted it,

4NG Fanatics

saying: Kill both;
then cut out her eyes and send them,
Also cut out his tongue and send it;
I will want my proof.

The mother,
now the grandmother --
a strange vocation to be a mother at all --
told them to run off in the woods.
The queen named her son
Painbringer
and fled to a safe cottage in the woods.
She and Painbringer were so good in the woods
that her hands grew back.
The ten fingers budding like asparagus,
the palms as whole as pancakes,
as soft and pink as face powder.

The king returned to the castle
and heard the news from his mother
and then he set out for seven years in the woods

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

never once eating a thing,
or so he said,
doing far better than Mahatma Ghandi.

He was good and kind as I have already said
So he found his beloved.
She brought forth the silver hands.
She brought froth Painbringer
and he realized they were his,
though both now unfortunately whole.
Now the butchers will come to me,
he thought, for I have lost my luck.
It put an insidious fear in him
like a tongue depressor held fast
at the back of your throat.
But he was good and kind
so he made the best of it
like a switch hitter.

They returned to the castle
and had a second wedding feast.

4NG Fanatics

He put a ring on her finger this time
and they danced like dandies.
All their lives they kept the silver hands,
polished daily,
a kind of purple heart,
a talisman,
A yellow star.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Anne Sextion
Book: Transformations
ISBN: 978-0618083435
Publisher: Mariner Books
Date (Month/Year): Feb 2001

AWARD HISTORY

2009 National Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY